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By Carlo Martuscelli · Sep 17, 2026, 4:24 PM · [View in your browser](#)

BRUSSELS — Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič will meet his Chinese counterpart, Wang Wentao, in Beijing on Oct. 8-9 as talks on rebalancing the EU's trading relationship with China enter their decisive phase.

The announcement followed a videocall between Šefčovič and Wang on Thursday, and comes a day after European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen said trade relations with China had reached a "tipping point."

The October meeting is part of the EU's ongoing Trade and Investment Consultation mechanism, a series of consultations as the bloc tries to reach an agreement with China to narrow the EU's €1-billion-a-day trade deficit.

Šefčovič has said that the October meeting will serve as a deadline for the talks, by which time the two sides should have made material progress. EU leaders will review the outcome at a summit in Brussels on Oct. 15-16.

The European Council meeting could serve as an opportunity for the European Commission to rally support from the capitals for more decisive trade action against China, should it judge that insufficient progress has been made.

Von der Leyen, in her annual State of the Union address on Wednesday, said it was vital for the dialogue to deliver results. She said the EU would "use all tools at our disposal to rebalance our relationship," without being more specific.

The Commission's deputy chief spokesperson, Olof Gill, said the call between Šefčovič and Wang lasted over an hour.

"They covered well-known issues, notably the management of Chinese exports to the EU, EU access to the Chinese market, and export controls on rare earths," Gill said.

Gill underlined that while "engagement remains a priority," it was important that "concrete outcomes" are delivered at the October meeting. "That outcome needs to be credible," he added.

The EU's trade deficit with China stood at nearly €240 billion in the year through July, up 12 percent from the same period a year earlier.

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